

Quebec Elects a Party That Wants Independence From Canada

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Voters in Quebec, a **province** in Canada, chose a new government in an election on Monday. The Parti Québécois, or PQ, is projected to have won enough seats to form a **minority government**. A **minority government** has the most seats but not more than half, so it needs help from other parties to pass its plans.

The PQ wants Quebec to become **independent**, or separate from the rest of Canada. It has promised to hold a public vote, called a **referendum**, on that question. This is the first time the PQ has been in power since 2014. Its leader, Paul St-Pierre Plamondon, is set to become Quebec's new **premier**, which is like a governor in the United States.

In his victory speech, St-Pierre Plamondon talked about his independence plans. He said, "Our national destiny will be achieved one day." He also promised to be "the **premier** of everyone in Quebec." He has said a **referendum** would happen only after President Donald Trump leaves office. The United States and Canada are in a trade dispute over Trump's tariffs, which are taxes on imported goods.

It is not clear how the PQ could hold a **referendum**. The rival parties it would need for support are against independence.

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney congratulated St-Pierre Plamondon. Carney said, "Building a stronger Quebec is at the heart of our mission to build a stronger Canada." The result could still lead to disagreements between Quebec and Canada's national government over issues such as immigration and the **monarchy**. St-Pierre Plamondon has promised to "abolish the **monarchy** in Quebec" and use that money for social services instead.

The party that ran Quebec before, the Coalition Avenir Québec, is not projected to have won a single seat.

Word Treasure

province -- A province is a region of Canada with its own government, similar to a U.S. state.

minority government -- A minority government is led by the party with the most seats but less than half of them.

independent -- Independent means ruling yourself instead of being part of another country.

referendum -- A referendum is a vote where citizens decide one important question directly.

premier -- A premier is the head of a Canadian province's government.

monarchy -- A monarchy is a system with a king or queen as head of state.

Background you need

Canada is divided into provinces, and each province elects its own government to handle matters such as schools and health care.

Quebec is a mostly French-speaking province, and the Parti Québécois has long argued that it should become its own country.

A referendum is a vote in which all citizens answer one question directly, such as whether Quebec should separate from Canada.

In a minority government, the leading party has fewer than half the seats, so it needs votes from rival parties to pass its plans.

Break it down

LEAD: Quebec voters chose a new provincial government on Monday

KEY EVENT: The Parti Québécois is projected to form a minority government

+ - WHO: PQ leader Paul St-Pierre Plamondon, set to become premier

+ - WHERE: Quebec, a province of Canada

+ - WHEN: Monday's election, first PQ win since 2014

GOAL: The PQ wants independence and has promised a referendum

REACTION: Prime Minister Mark Carney congratulated St-Pierre Plamondon

OPEN QUESTION: It is unclear how a referendum could happen when rival parties oppose independence

Why it matters

The result could test Canada's unity and lead to disagreements between Quebec and Canada's national government over immigration and the monarchy.

Test what you remember

1. Which party is projected to form Quebec's new government?
 - (A) The Liberals
 - (B) The Conservatives
 - (C) The Parti Québécois
 - (D) The Coalition Avenir Québec
2. What kind of government is the PQ expected to form?
 - (A) A minority government
 - (B) No government
 - (C) A majority government
 - (D) A military government
3. What does the PQ want for Quebec?
 - (A) To change its language
 - (B) To join the United States
 - (C) To become independent from Canada
 - (D) To become Canada's capital
4. When was the PQ last in power before this election?
 - (A) 2014
 - (B) 1990
 - (C) 2022
 - (D) 2020
5. When has St-Pierre Plamondon said a referendum would happen?
 - (A) Next week
 - (B) Before the election
 - (C) Never
 - (D) After President Donald Trump leaves office
6. How did the Coalition Avenir Québec do in the election?
 - (A) It is not projected to have won a single seat
 - (B) It won the most seats
 - (C) It won exactly half the seats
 - (D) It formed a coalition with the PQ

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Paul St-Pierre Plamondon and the PQ:** They want Quebec to become independent and have promised a referendum, while vowing to be the premier of everyone in Quebec.
2. **Prime Minister Mark Carney:** He congratulated St-Pierre Plamondon and said building a stronger Quebec is at the heart of building a stronger Canada.
3. **Rival parties:** They oppose independence, which makes it unclear how a referendum could happen.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):